

'That is very pretty,' said D'Artagnan.

'It is superb!' said Porthos.

'And yet,' resumed D'Artagnan, throwing his eyes over Aramis, 'you don't mean to bury yourself here forever?'

'Pardon me. Only I do not admit the word bury.'

'But it seems to me, that at this distance from Paris a man is buried, or nearly so.'

'My friend, I am getting old,' said Aramis; 'the noise and bustle of a city no longer suit me. At fifty-seven we ought to seek calm and meditation. I have found them here. What is there more beautiful, and stern at the same time, than this old Armorica. I find here, dear D'Artagnan, all that is opposite to what I formerly loved, and that is what must happen at the end of life, which is opposite to the beginning. A little of my old pleasure of former times still comes to salute me here, now and then, without diverting me from the road of salvation. I am still of this world, and yet every step that I take brings me nearer to God.'

'Eloquent, wise and discreet; you are an accomplished prelate, Aramis, and I offer you my congratulations.'

'But,' said Aramis smiling, 'you did not come here only for the purpose of paying me compliments. Speak; what brings you hither? May it be that, in some fashion or other, you want me?'

'Thank God, no, my friend,' said D'Artagnan, 'it is nothing of that kind.—I am rich and free.'

'Rich!' exclaimed Aramis.

'Yes, rich for me; not for you or Porthos, understand. I have an income of about fifteen thousand livres.'

Aramis looked at him suspiciously. He could not believe—particularly on seeing his friend in such humble guise—that he had made so fine a fortune. Then D'Artagnan, seeing that the hour of explanations was come, related the history of his English adventures. During the recital he saw, ten times, the eyes of the prelate sparkle, and his slender fingers work convulsively. As to Porthos, it was not admiration he manifested for D'Artagnan; it was enthusiasm, it was delirium. When D'Artagnan had finished, 'Well!' said Aramis.

'Well!' said D'Artagnan, 'you see, then, I have in England friends and property, in France a treasure. If your heart tells you so, I offer them to you. That is what I came here for.'

However firm was his look, he could not this time support the look of Aramis. He allowed, therefore, his eye to stray upon Porthos—like the sword which yields to too powerful a pressure, and seeks another road.

'At all events,' said the bishop, 'you have assumed a singular traveling costume, old friend.'

'Frightful! I know it is. You may understand why I would not travel as a cavalier or a noble; since I became rich, I am miserly.'

'And you say, then, you came to Belle-Isle?' said Aramis, without transition.

'Yes,' replied D'Artagnan; 'I knew I should find you and Porthos there.'

'Find me!' cried Aramis. 'Me! for the last year past I have not once crossed the sea.'

'Oh,' said D'Artagnan, 'I should never have supposed you such a house-keeper.'

'Ah, dear friend, I must tell you that I am no longer the Aramis of former times. Riding on horseback is unpleasant to me; the sea fatigues me. I am a poor, ailing priest, always complaining, always grumbling, and inclined to the austeries which appear to accord with old age,—preliminary parleyings with death. I linger, my dear D'Artagnan, I linger.'

'Well, that is all the better, my friend, for we shall probably be neighbors soon.'

'Bah!' said Aramis with a degree of surprise he did not even seek to dissemble. 'You my neighbour!'

'Mordieux! yes.'

'How so?'

'I am about to purchase some very profitable salt-mines, which are situated between Piriac and Le Croisic. Imagine, my dear friend, a clear profit of twelve per cent. Never any deficiency, never any idle expenses; the ocean, faithful and regular, brings every twelve hours its contingency to my coffers. I am the first Parisian who has dreamt of such a speculation. Do not say anything about it, I beg of you, and in a short time we will communicate on the matter. I am to have three leagues of country for thirty thousand livres.'

Aramis darted a look at Porthos, as if to ask if all this were true, if some snare were not concealed beneath this outward indifference. But soon, as if ashamed of having consulted this poor auxiliary, he collected all his forces for a fresh assault and new defense. 'I heard that you had had some difference with the court, but that you had come out of it as you know how to get through everything, D'Aragnan, with the honours of war.'

'I' said the musketeer, with a burst of laughter that did not conceal his embarrassment: for, from those words, Aramis was not unlikely to be acquainted with his last relations with the king. 'I! Oh, tell me all about that, pray, Aramis?'

'Yes, it was related to me, a poor bishop, lost in the middle of the Landes, that the king had taken you as the confidant of his amours.'

'With whom?'

'With Mademoiselle de Mancini.'

D'Aragnan breathed freely again. 'Ah! I don't say no to that,' replied he.

'It appears that the king took you one morning, over the bridge of Blois to talk with his lady-love.'

'That's true,' said D'Aragnan. 'And you know that, do you? Well, then, you must know that the same day I gave in my resignation!'

'What, sincerely?'

'Nothing more so.'

'It was after that, then, that you went to the Comte de la Fère's?'

'Yes.'

'Afterwards to me?'

'Yes.'

'And then Porthos?'

'Yes.'

'Was it in order to pay us a simple visit?'

'No, I did no know you were engaged, and I wished to take you with me into England.'

'Yes, I understand; and then you executed alone, wonderful man as you are, what you wanted to propose to us all four. I suspected you had something to do with that famous restoration, when I learned that you had been seen at King Charles's receptions, and that he appeared to

'Eh! yes, he has been seeking you, Aramis,' said Porthos, 'and the proof is that he has unharbored me at Belle-Isle. That is amiable, is it not?'

'Ah! yes,' said Aramis, 'at Belle-Isle! certainly!'

'Good!' said D'Aragnan; 'there is my booby Porthos, without thinking of it, has fired the first cannon of attack.'

'At Belle-Isle!' said Aramis, 'in that hole, in that desert! That is kind, indeed!'

'And it was I who told him you were at Vannes,' continued Porthos, in the same tone.

D'Aragnan armed his mouth with a finesse almost ironical.

'Yes, I knew; but I was willing to see,' replied he.

'To see what?'

'If our old friendship still held out; if, on seeing each other, our hearts, hardened as they are by age, would still let the old cry of joy escape, which salutes the coming of a friend.'

'Well, and you must have been satisfied,' said Aramis.

'So, so.'

'How is that?'

'Yes, Porthos said hush! and you—'

'Well! and I?'

'And you gave me your benediction.'

'What would you have, my friend?' said Aramis, smiling; 'that is the most precious thing that a poor prelate, like me, has to give.'

'Indeed, my dear friend!'

'Doubtless.'

'And yet they say at Paris that the bishopric of Vannes is one of the best in France.'

'Ah! you are now speaking of temporal wealth,' said Aramis, with a careless air.

'To be sure, I wish to speak of that; I hold by it, on my part.'

'In that case, let me speak of it,' said Aramis, with a smile.

'You own yourself to be one of the richest prelates in France?'

'My friend, since you ask me to give you an account, I will tell you that the bishopric of Vannes is worth about twenty thousand livres a year, neither more nor less. It is a diocese which contains a hundred and sixty parishes.'

never changes, and appears to be incorporated in the person, of whom it has become the natural emanation. In this case only, the perfume had retained something of the religious sublimity of incense. It no longer intoxicated, it penetrated; it no longer inspired desire, it inspired respect. Aramis, on entering the chamber, did not hesitate an instant; and without pronouncing one word, which, whatever it might be, would have been cold on such an occasion, he went straight up to the musketeer, so well disguised under the costume of M. Agnan, and pressed him in his arms with a tenderness which the most distrustful could not have suspected of coldness or affectation.

D'Artagnan, on his part, embraced him with equal ardour. Porthos pressed the delicate hand of Aramis in his immense hands, and D'Artagnan remarked that His Greatness gave him his left hand, probably from habit, seeing that Porthos already ten times had been near injuring his fingers covered with rings, by pounding his flesh in the vise of his fist. Warned by the pain, Aramis was cautious, and only presented flesh to be bruised, and not fingers to be crushed, against the gold or the angles of diamonds.

Between two embraces, Aramis looked D'Artagnan in the face, offered him a chair, sitting down himself in the shade, observing that the light fell full upon the face of his interlocutor. This manoeuvre, familiar to diplomats and women, resembles much the advantage of the guard which, according to their skill or habit, combatants endeavour to take on the ground at a duel. D'Artagnan was not the dupe of this manoeuvre; but he did not appear to perceive it. He felt himself caught; but, precisely because he was caught he felt himself on the road to discovery, and it little imported to him, old *conductiere* as he was, to be beaten in appearance, provided he drew from his pretended defeat the advantages of victory. Aramis began the conversation.

'Ah! dear friend! my good D'Artagnan,' said he, 'what an excellent chance!'

'It is a chance, my reverend companion,' said D'Artagnan, 'that I will call friendship. I seek you, as I always have sought you, when I had any grand enterprise to propose to you, or some hours of liberty to give you.'

'Ah! indeed,' said Aramis, without explosion, 'you have been seeking me?'

treat you like a friend, or rather like a person to whom he was under an obligation.'

'But how the devil did you learn all that?' asked D'Artagnan, who began to fear that the investigation of Aramis had extended further than he wished.

'Dear D'Artagnan,' said the prelate, 'my friendship resembles, in a degree, the solicitude of that night watch whom we have in the little tower of the mole, at the extremity of the quay. That brave man, every night, lights a lantern to direct the barks that come from sea. He is concealed in his sentry-box, and the fishermen do not see him; but he follows them with interest; he divines them; he calls them; he attracts them into the way to the port. I resemble this watcher; from time to time some news reaches me, and recalls to my remembrance all those I loved. Then I follow the friends of old days over the stormy ocean of the world, I, a poor watcher, to whom God has kindly given the shelter of a sentry-box.'

'Well, what did I do when I came from England?'

'Ah! there,' replied Aramis, 'you get beyond my depth. I know nothing of you since your return. D'Artagnan, my eyes are dim. I regretted you did not think of me. I wept over your forgetfulness. I was wrong. I see you again, and it is a festival, a great festival. I assure you, solemnly! How is Athos?'

'Very well, thank you.'

'And our young pupil, Raoul?'

'He seems to have inherited the skill of his father, Athos, and the strength of his tutor, Porthos.'

'And on what occasion have you been able to judge of that?'

'Eh! mon Dieu! on the eve of my departure from Paris.'

'Indeed! tell me all about it!'

'Yes; there was an execution at the Grève, and in consequence of that execution, a riot. We happened, by accident, to be in the riot; and in this riot we were obliged to have recourse to our swords. And he did wonders.'

'Bah! what did he do?'

'Why, in the first place, he threw a man out of the window, as he would have flung a sack full of flock.'

'Come, that's pretty well,' said Porthos.

‘Then he drew, and cut and thrust away, as we fellows used to do in the good old times.’

‘And what was the cause of this riot?’ said Porthos.

D’Artagnan remarked upon the face of Aramis a complete indifference to this question of Porthos. ‘Why,’ said he, fixing his eyes upon Aramis, ‘on account of the two farmers of the revenue, friends of M. Fouquet, whom the king forced to disgorge their plunder, and then hanged them.’ A scarcely perceptible contraction of the prelate’s brow showed that he had heard D’Artagnan’s reply. ‘Oh, oh!’ said Porthos; ‘and what were the names of these friends of M. Fouquet?’

‘MM. d’Eymeris and Lyodot,’ said D’Artagnan. ‘Do you know these names, Aramis?’

‘No,’ said the prelate, disdainfully; ‘they sound like the names of financiers.’

‘Exactly; so they were.’

‘Oh! M. Fouquet allows his friends to be hanged, then,’ said Porthos.

‘And why not?’ said Aramis.

‘Why, it seems to me—’

‘If these culprits were hanged, it was by order of the king. Now M. Fouquet, although superintendent of the finances, has not, I believe, the right of life and death.’

‘That may be,’ said Porthos; ‘but in the place of M. Fouquet—’

Aramis was afraid Porthos was about to say something awkward, so interrupted him. ‘Come, D’Artagnan,’ said he; ‘this is quite enough about other people, let us talk a little about you.’

‘Of me you know all that I can tell you. On the contrary let me hear a little about you, Aramis.’

‘I have told you, my friend. There is nothing of Aramis left in me.’

‘Nor of the Abbé d’Herblay even?’

‘No, not even of him. You see a man whom Providence has taken by the hand, whom he has conducted to a position that he could never have dared even to hope for.’

‘Providence?’ asked D’Artagnan.

‘Yes.’

‘Well, that is strange! I was told it was M. Fouquet.’

Chapter LXXII

The Grandeur of the Bishop of Vannes



PORTHOS and D’Artagnan had entered the bishop’s residence by a private door, as his personal friends. Of course, Porthos served D’Artagnan as guide. The worthy baron comported himself everywhere rather as if he were at home. Nevertheless, whether it was a tacit acknowledgment of the sanctity of the personage of Aramis and his character, or the habit of respecting him who imposed upon him morally, a worthy habit which had always made Porthos a model soldier and an excellent companion; for all these reasons, say we, Porthos preserved in the palace of His Greatness the Bishop of Vannes a sort of reserve which D’Artagnan remarked at once, in the attitude he took with respect to the valets and officers. And yet this reserve did not go so far as to prevent his asking questions. Porthos questioned. They learned that His Greatness had just returned to his apartment and was preparing to appear in familiar intimacy, less majestic than he had appeared with his flock. After a quarter of an hour, which D’Artagnan and Porthos passed in looking mutually at each other with the white of their eyes, and turning their thumbs in all the different evolutions which go from north to south, a door of the chamber opened and His Greatness appeared, dressed in the undress, complete, of a prelate. Aramis carried his head high, like a man accustomed to command: his violet robe was tucked up on one side, and his white hand was on his hip. He had retained the fine moustache, and the lengthened royale of the time of Louis XIII. He exhaled, on entering, that delicate perfume which, among elegant men and women of high fashion,

'Who told you that?' cried Aramis, without being able, with all the power of his will, to prevent the colour rising to his cheeks.

'Ma foi! why, Bazin!'

'The fool!'

'I do not say he is a man of genius, it is true; but he told me so; and after him, I repeat it to you.'

'I have never even seen M. Fouquet,' replied Aramis with a look as pure and calm as that of a virgin who has never told a lie.

'Well, but if you had seen him and known him, there is no harm in that,' replied D'Artagnan. 'M. Fouquet is a very good sort of a man.'

'Humph!'

'A great politician.' Aramis made a gesture of indifference.

'An all-powerful minister.'

'I only hold to the king and the pope.'

'Dame! listen then,' said D'Artagnan, in the most natural tone imaginable. 'I said that because everybody here swears by M. Fouquet. The plain is M. Fouquet's; the salt-mines I am about to buy are M. Fouquet's; the island in which Porthos studies topography is M. Fouquet's; the garrison is M. Fouquet's; the galleys are M. Fouquet's. I confess, then, that nothing would have surprised me in your enfeoffment, or rather in that of your diocese, to M. Fouquet. He is a different master from the king, that is all; but quite as powerful as Louis.'

'Thank God! I am not vassal to anybody; I belong to nobody, and am entirely my own master,' replied Aramis, who, during this conversation, followed with his eye every gesture of D'Artagnan, every glance of Porthos. But D'Artagnan was impassible and Porthos motionless; the thrusts aimed so skillfully were parried by an able adversary; not one hit the mark. Nevertheless, both began to feel the fatigue of such a contest, and the announcement of supper was well received by everybody. Supper changed the course of conversation. Besides, they felt that, upon their guard as each one had been, they could neither of them boast of having the advantage. Porthos had understood nothing of what had been meant. He had held himself motionless, because Aramis had made him a sign not to stir. Supper, for him, was nothing but supper; but that was quite enough for Porthos. The supper, then, went off very well. D'Artagnan was in high spirits. Aramis exceeded himself in kind affability. Porthos are

like old Pelops. Their talk was of war, finance, the arts, and love. Aramis played astonishment at every word of politics D'Artagnan risked. This long series of surprises increased the mistrust of D'Artagnan, as the eternal indifference of D'Artagnan provoked the suspicions of Aramis. At length D'Artagnan, designedly, uttered the name of Colbert: he had reserved that stroke for the last.

'Who is this Colbert?' asked the bishop.

'Oh! come,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'that is too strong! We must be careful, mordoux! we must be careful.'

And he then gave Aramis all the information respecting M. Colbert he could desire. The supper, or rather, the conversation, was prolonged till one o'clock in the morning between D'Artagnan and Aramis. At ten o'clock precisely, Porthos had fallen asleep in his chair and snored like an organ. At midnight he woke up and they sent him to bed. 'Hum!' said he, 'I was near falling asleep; but that was all very interesting you were talking about.'

At one o'clock Aramis conducted D'Artagnan to the chamber destined for him, which was the best in the episcopal residence. Two servants were placed at his command. 'To-morrow, at eight o'clock,' said he, taking leave of D'Artagnan, 'we will take, if agreeable to you, a ride on horseback with Porthos.'

'At eight o'clock!' said D'Artagnan; 'so late?'

'You know that I require seven hours' sleep,' said Aramis.

'That is true.'

'Good-night, dear friend!' And he embraced the musketeer cordially. D'Artagnan allowed him to depart; then, as soon as the door closed, 'Good!' cried he, 'at five o'clock I will be on foot.'

This determination being made, he went to bed and quietly, 'put two and two together,' as people say.

now,—see, what a hurry he is in; do you see how the *cortège* is increasing its speed? He is eager to join us and embrace us, is that dear Aramis.'

'That is true,' replied D'Artagnan, aloud.—'Then to himself:—'It is equally true he has seen me, the fox, and will have time to prepare himself to receive me.'

But the procession had passed; the road was free. D'Artagnan and Porthos walked straight up to the episcopal palace, which was surrounded by a numerous crowd anxious to see the prelate return. D'Artagnan remarked that this crowd was composed principally of citizens and military men. He recognized in the nature of these partisans the address of his friend. Aramis was not the man to seek for a useless popularity. He cared very little for being beloved by people who could be of no service to him. Women, children, and old men, that is to say, the *cortège* of ordinary pastors; was not the *cortège* for him.

Ten minutes after the two friends had passed the threshold of the palace, Aramis returned like a triumphant conqueror; the soldiers presented arms to him as to a superior; the citizens bowed to him as to a friend and a patron, rather than as a head of the Church. There was something in Aramis resembling those Roman senators who had their doors always surrounded by clients. At the foot of the steps, he had a conference of half a minute with a Jesuit, who, in order to speak to him more secretly, passed his head under the dais. He then re-entered his palace; the doors closed slowly, and the crowd melted away, whilst chants and prayers were still resounding abroad. It was a magnificent day. Earthly perfumes were mingled with the perfumes of the air and the sea. The city breathed happiness, joy, and strength. D'Artagnan felt something like the presence of an invisible hand which had, all-powerfully, created this strength, this joy, this happiness, and spread everywhere these perfumes.

'Oh! oh!' said he, 'Porthos has got fat; but Aramis is grown taller.'

his large black eyes, with their long lashes, and turned them without hesitation towards the spot whence the exclamation proceeded. At a glance, he saw Porthos and D'Artagnan close to him. On his part, D'Artagnan, thanks to the keenness of his sight, had seen all, seized all. The full portrait of the prelate had entered his memory, never to leave it. One thing had particularly struck D'Artagnan. On perceiving him, Aramis had coloured, then he had concentrated under his eyelids the fire of the look of the master, and the indefinable affection of the friend. It was evident that Aramis had asked himself this question:—'Why is D'Artagnan with Porthos, and what does he want at Vannes?' Aramis comprehended all that was passing in the mind of D'Artagnan, on turning his look upon him again, and seeing that he had not lowered his eyes. He knew the acuteness and intelligence of his friend; he feared to let him divine the secret of his blush and his astonishment. He was still the same Aramis, always having a secret to conceal. Therefore, to put an end to his look of an inquisitor, which it was necessary to get rid of at all events, as, at any price, a general extinguishes a battery which annoys him, Aramis stretched forth his beautiful white hand, upon which sparkled the amethyst of the pastoral ring: he cut the air with sign of the cross, and poured out his benediction upon his two friends. Perhaps thoughtful and absent, D'Artagnan, impious in spite of himself, might not have bent beneath this holy benediction; but Porthos saw his distraction, and laying his friendly hand upon the back of his companion, he crushed him down towards the earth. D'Artagnan was forced to give way; indeed, he was little short of being flat on the ground. In the meantime Aramis had passed. D'Artagnan, like Antæus, had only touched the ground, and he turned towards Porthos, almost angry. But there was no mistaking the intention of the brave Hercules; it was a feeling of religious propriety that had influenced him. Besides, speech with Porthos, instead of disguising his thought, always completed it.

'It is very polite of him,' said he, 'to have given his benediction to us alone. Decidedly, he is a holy man, and a brave man.' Less convinced than Porthos, D'Artagnan made no reply.

'Observe my friend,' continued Porthos, 'he has seen us; and, instead of continuing to walk on at the simple pace of the procession, as he did just

Chapter LXXIII

In Which Porthos Begins To Be Sorry For Having Come With D'Artagnan



CARCELY had D'Artagnan extinguished his taper, when Aramis, who had watched through his curtains the last glimmer of light in his friend's apartment, traversed the corridor on tiptoe, and went to Porthos's room. The giant who had been in bed nearly an hour and a half, lay grandly stretched out on the down bed. He was in that happy calm of the first sleep, which, with Porthos, resisted the noise of bells or the report of cannon: his head swam in that soft oscillation which reminds us of the soothing movement of a ship. In a moment Porthos would have begun to dream. The door of the chamber opened softly under the delicate pressure of the hand of Aramis. The bishop approached the sleeper. A thick carpet deadened his steps, besides which Porthos snored in a manner to drown all noise. He laid one hand on his shoulder—'Rouse,' said he, 'wake up, my dear Porthos.' The voice of Aramis was soft and kind, but it conveyed more than a notice,—it conveyed an order. His hand was light, but it indicated danger. Porthos heard the voice and felt the hand of Aramis, even in the depth of sleep. He started up. 'Who goes there?' cried he, in his giant's voice.

'Hush! hush! It is I,' said Aramis.

'You, my friend? And what the devil do you wake me for?'

'To tell you that you must set off directly.'

'Set off?'

'Yes.'

'Where for?'

'For Paris.'

Porthos bounded up in his bed, and then sank back down again, fixing his great eyes in agitation upon Aramis.

'For Paris?'

'Yes.'

'A hundred leagues?' said he.

'A hundred and four,' replied the bishop.

'Oh! mon Dieu!' sighed Porthos, lying down again, like children who contend with their bonne to gain an hour or two more sleep.

'Thirty hours' riding,' said Aramis, firmly. 'You know there are good relays.'

Porthos pushed out one leg, allowing a groan to escape him.

'Come, come! my friend,' insisted the prelate with a sort of impatience.

Porthos drew the other leg out of the bed. 'And is it absolutely necessary that I should go, at once?'

'Urgently necessary.'

Porthos got upon his feet, and began to shake both walls and floors with his steps of a marble statue.

'Hush! hush! for the love of Heaven, my dear Porthos!' said Aramis,

'you will wake somebody.'

'Ah! that's true,' replied Porthos, in a voice of thunder, 'I forgot that; but be satisfied, I am on guard.' And so saying, he let fall a belt loaded with his sword and pistols, and a purse, from which the crowns escaped with a vibrating and prolonged noise. This noise made the blood of Aramis boil, whilst it drew from Porthos a formidable burst of laughter. 'How droll that is!' said he, in the same voice.

'Not so loud, Porthos, not so loud.'

'True, true!' and he lowered his voice a half-note.

'I was going to say,' continued Porthos, 'that it is droll that we are never so slow as when we are in a hurry, and never make so much noise as when we wish to be silent.'

'Yes, that is true; but let us give the proverb the lie, Porthos; let us make haste, and hold our tongue.'

'And high time we were,' thought D'Aragnan, 'for Aramis's horse is melting away like a steed of ice.'

They entered almost at the same instant the faubourg; but scarcely had they gone a hundred paces when they were surprised to find the streets strewn with leaves and flowers. Against the old walls of Vannes, hung the oldest and the strangest tapestries of France. From over balconies fell long white sheets struck all over with bouquets. The streets were deserted; it was plain the entire population was assembled on one point. The blinds were closed, and the breeze penetrated into the houses under the hangings, which cast long, black shades between their places of issue and the walls. Suddenly, at the turning of a street, chants struck the ears of the newly arrived travelers. A crowd in holiday garb appeared through the vapors of incense which mounted to the heavens in blue fleeces, and clouds of rose-leaves fluttered as high as the first stories. Above all heads were to be seen the cross and banners, the sacred symbols of religion. Then, beneath these crosses and banners, as if protected by them, walked a whole world of young girls clothed in white, crowned with corn-flowers. At the two sides of the street, inclosing the cortège, marched the guards of the garrison, carrying bouquets in the barrels of their muskets and on the points of their lances. This was the procession.

Whilst D'Aragnan and Porthos were looking on with critical glances, which disguised an extreme impatience to get forward, a magnificent dais approached preceded by a hundred Jesuits and a hundred Dominicans, and escorted by two archdeacons, a treasurer, a penitent and twelve canons. A singer with a thundering voice—a man certainly picked out from all the voices of France, as was the drum-major of the imperial guard from all the giants of the empire—escorted by four other chanters, who appeared to be there only to serve him as an accompaniment, made the air resound, and the windows of the houses vibrate. Under the dais appeared a pale and noble countenance with black eyes, black hair streaked with threads of white, a delicate, compressed mouth, a prominent and angular chin. His head, full of graceful majesty, was covered with the episcopal mitre, a headdress which gave it, in addition to the character of sovereignty, that of asceticism and evangelical meditation.

'Aramis!' cried the musketeer, involuntarily, as this lofty countenance passed before him. The prelate started at the sound of the voice. He raised